

Operation Southern Spear vessel strikes - public-record reconstruction

Build a provenance-first, non-graphic first-pass reconstruction of the U.S. lethal vessel-strike campaign that began near Venezuela and expanded across the Caribbean and eastern Pacific, while preserving target and cargo attribution, incomplete public accounting, casualty-category changes, survivor and SAR uncertainty, legal disputes, civil allegations, rights limits, and the absence of metric reconstruction inputs.

SOURCES 20 reviewed public locators	CLAIMS 24 source-linked propositions	CONFLICTS 7 preserved contradiction ledgers	PRESERVED BODIES 0 rights-permitted remote bodies
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STATUS: WORKING / RESEARCH CUTOFF: 2026-07-17T18:00:00Z / SCHEMA: 2.0.0

This analysis is not a finding of guilt, certification, metric-validation statement, court-admissibility opinion, or public-release approval.

Executive summary

ESTABLISHED IN PACKAGE

The public vessel-strike campaign began with a U.S.-announced attack on September 2, 2025 and later operated under the name Operation Southern Spear.

ESTABLISHED IN PACKAGE

Later official briefings and reporting state that nine people were killed in the first September 2 strike and two survivors clinging to wreckage were killed in a follow-on strike.

ESTABLISHED IN PACKAGE

Operation Southern Spear was formally announced in November 2025, after the first vessel strikes had already occurred.

ATTRIBUTED CLAIM

U.S. officials asserted that the September 2 vessel departed Venezuela, was operated by Tren de Aragua, carried narcotics, and that eleven people were killed.

ATTRIBUTED CLAIM

The administration reported Article II and self-defense grounds and later characterized the United States as being in a non-international armed conflict with designated cartels or drug-trafficking organizations.

OPEN EVIDENCE NEED

What independently verifiable evidence identifies the vessel, occupants, cargo, affiliation, route, and exact position?

OPEN EVIDENCE NEED

What does the complete, unedited sensor record show between the two strikes?

Method and evidence profile

INCLUSION RULE

Public records and specifically reviewed metadata-only fixtures relevant to the defined investigation scope.

EXCLUSION RULE

No crawler execution, authenticated access, raw third-party body retention, publication, or unsupported identity, guilt, trajectory, or metric inference.

SOURCE HIERARCHY

preserved primary evidence > official record >
independent reporting > attributed analysis > unresolved
assertion

CLAIM EVIDENCE STATES

authenticated official record		9
attributed unverified		5
independently corroborated		4
inferred		3
disputed		2
unresolved		1

SOURCE AUTHORITY CLASSES

primary official		1 2
published secondary		8

Chronology

NO.	SOURCE TIME	EVENT	SOURCE-BOUNDED DESCRIPTION
01	September 2, 2025	First publicly announced vessel strike	The U.S. announces a Caribbean strike tied to a vessel alleged to have departed Venezuela; target, cargo, affiliation, casualty, and follow-on-strike details remain source-specific.
02	October 14, 2025	October 14 strike later challenged	U.S. officials report six killed; the Burnley plaintiffs later contest the trafficking characterization for two alleged occupants.
03	November 13, 2025	Operation Southern Spear formally named	The military campaign receives its formal operation name after the first vessel strikes.
04	January 23, 2026	January 23 survivor incident	SOUTHCOM reports two killed, one survivor, and SAR notification.
05	March 19, 2026	March 19 survivor incident	SOUTHCOM reports three survivors and SAR notification after an eastern Pacific strike.
06	March 31, 2026	Lead IG aggregate cutoff	The oversight report later records a public lower bound of 47 boats and 156 killed or presumed dead through March 31 while stating no complete public accounting was available.
07	May 11, 2026	Targeting-cycle evaluation announced	The Inspector General opens a targeting-procedure evaluation that does not purport to decide legality.

Chronology

NO.	SOURCE TIME	EVENT	SOURCE-BOUNDED DESCRIPTION
08	June 21, 2026	June 21 Caribbean strike	SOUTHCOM reports two killed, six survivors, and SAR notification; exact position, evidence packet, and survivor result are not disclosed in the release.
09	June 22, 2026 publication	AP current aggregate and correction	AP reports more than 60 attacks and more than 210 killed, and corrects the incident basin/date framing in its June 22 report.
10	July 17, 2026	Research cutoff	No later SOUTHCOM vessel-strike release, complete public ledger, completed legality review, or civil merits judgment was identified through the cutoff.

Contradiction register

Complete ledger versus public lower bounds	OPEN
The government says it cannot provide a complete public accounting, while oversight and reporting publish partial aggregates and a source-by-source lower bound.	Classified or non-public incidents Different strike, engagement, and vessel counting units Publication lag or correction history
Campaign casualty totals	EXPLAINED
Lead IG and AP totals use different dates and casualty categories; neither should overwrite the other.	Different cutoffs Immediate deaths versus presumed deaths Survivor outcomes changing after publication
Venezuela shorthand versus basin-wide campaign	EXPLAINED
Early incidents were framed near or from Venezuela, but the documented campaign extends across the Caribbean and eastern Pacific and usually lacks exact coordinates.	Political shorthand Origin, route, and strike location conflated Different incident subsets
International waters versus legal maritime zone	OPEN
Official international-waters wording is not enough to choose territorial sea, EEZ outside territorial sea, or high seas without coordinates and baselines.	High seas EEZ outside territorial sea Territorial sea
June 21 target and cargo status	OPEN
SOUTHCOM asserts DTO operation and trafficking; the public release does not expose the underlying intelligence or cargo proof.	Reliable classified evidence not publicly releasable Mistaken identification Correct vessel but disputed occupant or cargo characterization
October 14 occupant characterization	OPEN
The U.S. trafficking characterization conflicts with plaintiffs' allegation that two decedents were fishermen and farmworkers returning home; no merits ruling resolves the conflict.	Government classification supported by non-public evidence Plaintiffs' account supported by discovery Mixed occupant roles
September 2 follow-on strike	OPEN

The acknowledged follow-on strike and survivor deaths raise unresolved factual and legal questions that the public edited record and current oversight do not decide.

Continuing threat assessment
Vessel-destruction objective
Persons hors de combat

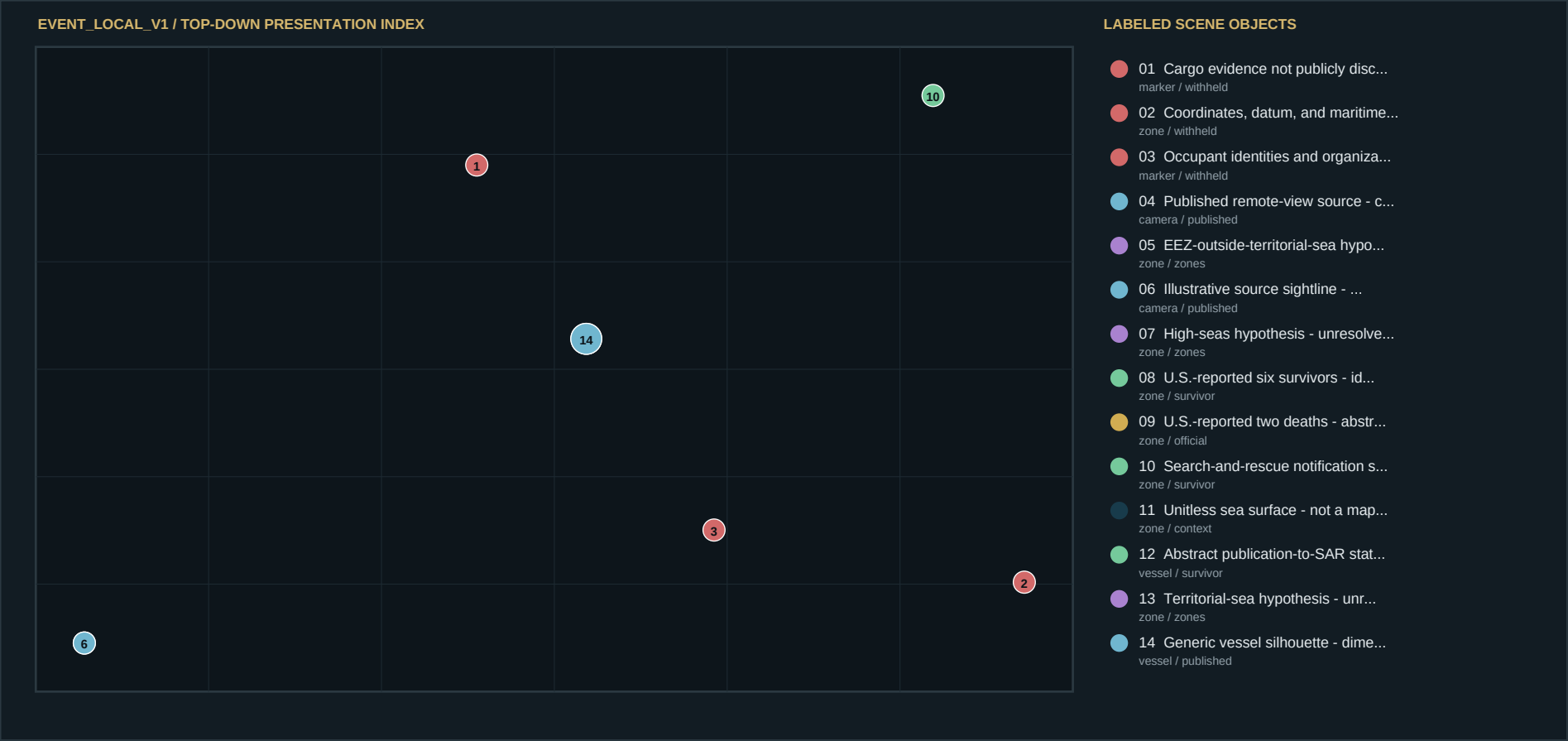
Spatial and integrity gates

ARTIFACT	FRAME	METRIC	MEASUREMENT	VALIDATION
Unitless maritime event cell	UNRESOLVED_MARITIME_ZONE	NO	DISABLED	not_metric
Target, cargo, identity, and coordinate unknowns	UNRESOLVED_MARITIME_ZONE	NO	DISABLED	not_metric
Mutually exclusive maritime-zone hypotheses	UNRESOLVED_MARITIME_ZONE	NO	DISABLED	not_metric
Attributed casualty-count states	UNRESOLVED_MARITIME_ZONE	NO	DISABLED	not_metric
Generic vessel and publication source	UNRESOLVED_MARITIME_ZONE	NO	DISABLED	not_metric
Survivor and SAR transition	UNRESOLVED_MARITIME_ZONE	NO	DISABLED	not_metric

STRUCTURAL VALIDATION	EVIDENCE AUTHENTICATION	PRESERVED SOURCE BODIES
passed_v2_audit	limited_metadata_only	0 of 20

Internal consistency does not authenticate remote source content. Measurements remain disabled for non-metric case scenes. Gaussian-splat products are visualization derivatives unless independently validated.

Labeled reconstruction view



This diagram is generated from the package's relational scene or normalized timing anchors. It contains no copied source pixels and does not add metric, geodetic, trajectory, identity, or legal conclusions.

Source appendix

ID	SOURCE	LOCATOR	PRESERVATION
S001	Operation Southern Spear, Report to Congress, January 1-March 31, 2026 Lead Inspectors General of the Departments of War and State https://media.defense.gov/2026/May/21/2003935694/-1/-1/1/OSS_Q2_MAR2026_FINAL_508.PDF	section: Strikes and Interdictions, page 10; legal basis, oversight, survivor, and campaign-limit sections	metadata_only
S002	U.S. Southern Command press-release archive U.S. Southern Command https://www.southcom.mil/News/PressReleases/Tag/321528/kinetic-strike/	section: Public vessel-strike releases through June 21, 2026	metadata_only
S003	Lethal Kinetic Strike, June 21, 2026 U.S. Southern Command https://www.southcom.mil/News/PressReleases/Article/4522545/lethal-kinetic-strike-june-21-2026/	section: Caribbean vessel, claimed target status, two reported deaths, six survivors, and SAR notification	metadata_only
S004	Lethal Kinetic Strike, June 21, 2026 - published video record Defense Visual Information Distribution Service https://www.dvidshub.net/video/1011842/lethal-kinetic-strike-june-21-2026	section: Edited government publication metadata and short video; remote bytes excluded	metadata_only
S005	Lethal Kinetic Strike, January 23, 2026 U.S. Southern Command https://www.southcom.mil/News/PressReleases/Article/4388870/lethal-kinetic-strike-jan-23-2026/	section: Two reported deaths, one survivor, and SAR notification	metadata_only
S006	Lethal Kinetic Strike, March 19, 2026 U.S. Southern Command https://www.southcom.mil/News/PressReleases/Article/4439576/lethal-kinetic-strike-march-19-2026/	section: Eastern Pacific vessel and three survivors with SAR notification	metadata_only

Source appendix

ID	SOURCE	LOCATOR	PRESERVATION
S007	US strike on an alleged drug boat kills 2, leaves 6 survivors, in the Caribbean Associated Press https://apnews.com/article/d97e406d3cb2b0246a5d055a58a338b6	section: Current aggregate, June 21 incident, evidence limits, survivor uncertainty, and correction note	metadata_only
S008	Timeline of U.S. strikes on alleged drug boats Associated Press https://apnews.com/article/trump-boat-strikes-caribbean-military-venezuela-timeline-2dd9d16f4f74d9dfa4aca76d3123678d	section: Early campaign chronology and incident-counting context	metadata_only
S009	Trump administration tells Congress the U.S. is in armed conflict with cartels Associated Press https://apnews.com/article/cb57804807e55a00ace60ad5f4d4f24d	section: Administration armed-conflict characterization and unlawful-combatant terminology	metadata_only
S010	US kills 6 people in strike on boat accused of carrying drugs near Venezuela Associated Press https://apnews.com/article/af1a784864268707a76755a98615563e	section: October 14 U.S. assertions, location description, casualties, and published-video description	metadata_only
S011	IACHR urges the United States to ensure respect for human rights in extraterritorial security operations Inter-American Commission on Human Rights https://www.oas.org/en/IACHR/jsForm/?File=%2Fen%2Fiachr%2Fmedia_center%2FReleases%2F2025%2F248.asp	section: Institutional human-rights assessment, early chronology, and accountability recommendations	metadata_only
S012	Special Procedures communication AL USA 30/2025 United Nations Office of the High Commissioner for Human Rights https://spcommreports.ohchr.org/TMResultsBase/DownloadPublicCommunicationFile?gld=30350	section: Concerns regarding the August order and September 2 strike under human-rights and international-law frameworks	metadata_only

Source appendix

ID	SOURCE	LOCATOR	PRESERVATION
S013	Burnley v. United States - Complaint U.S. District Court for the District of Massachusetts via ACLU of Massachusetts https://www.aclum.org/app/uploads/2026/01/1-2.pdf	section: Case 1:26-cv-10364, Document 1, allegations concerning two October 14 decedents	metadata_only
S014	Burnley v. United States docket CourtListener https://www.courtlistener.com/docket/72191479/burnley-v-united-states/	section: Civil Action 1:26-cv-10364 procedural docket through July 17, 2026	metadata_only
S015	S.3539 - September 2 vessel-strike video release bill United States Congress https://www.congress.gov/bill/119th-congress/senate-bill/3539/text	section: Proposed congressional and public release of unedited September 2 video	metadata_only
S016	Evaluation of U.S. Southern Command Joint Targeting Cycle Procedures Department of War Office of Inspector General https://www.dodig.mil/Reports/Audits-and-Evaluations/Article/4486668/project-announcement-evaluation-of-us-southern-command-joint-targeting-cycle-pr/	section: Ongoing review scope and express exclusion of legal-authority review	metadata_only
S017	Presidential War Powers report of September 4, 2025 Executive Office of the President via GovInfo https://www.govinfo.gov/content/pkg/CDOC-119hdoc92/pdf/CDOC-119hdoc92.pdf	section: Article II and self-defense rationale reported to Congress	metadata_only
S018	United Nations Convention on the Law of the Sea - Part II, Territorial Sea United Nations Division for Ocean Affairs and the Law of the Sea https://www.un.org/depts/los/convention_agreements/texts/unclos/part2.htm	section: Territorial-sea breadth and baseline framework	metadata_only

Source appendix

ID	SOURCE	LOCATOR	PRESERVATION
S019	United Nations Convention on the Law of the Sea - Part VII, High Seas United Nations Division for Ocean Affairs and the Law of the Sea https://www.un.org/depts/los/convention_agreements/texts/unclos/part7.htm	section: High-seas scope and treatment of persons in danger at sea	metadata_only
S020	What is the law of the sea? National Oceanic and Atmospheric Administration https://oceanservice.noaa.gov/facts/lawofsea.html	section: Plain-language distinctions among territorial sea, EEZ, and high seas	metadata_only